authorization is a shared service that often involves multiple teams, a single outdated rule can quietly weaken trust throughout the entire system.

That realization prompted ACME to develop a policy governance framework, a structured process for authoring, reviewing, deploying, and retiring authorization policies. Governance turned out to be more about assurance than control, making sure that policy decisions are traceable, explainable, and aligned with the company's goals. Just as Identity Governance and Administration (IGA) brought order to entitlements—defining who could request, approve, and review access—policy governance brought order to the logic that interprets those entitlements at runtime. Together, IGA and policy governance create a complete feedback loop for managing both the inputs and rules of dynamic authorization. We'll discuss IGA and policy governance later in this chapter.

This chapter examines how organizations like ACME progress from creating policies to governing them. It traces the lifecycle of policies in a dynamic authorization environment, showing how governance frameworks maintain trust and accountability across teams. It also links the operational aspect of IGA—the management of people and entitlements—with the policy side of authorization, where access decisions are made in real time. Together, they create a continuous feedback loop that ensures authorization aligns with business goals, meets regulations, and adapts to change.

14.1 Why governance matters for authorization

Authorization systems make decisions continuously, often thousands of times per second. Each decision results from a complex web of policies, data, and context, reflecting what the organization believes to be true at that moment. Governance ensures these decisions remain legitimate. It provides the enterprise with confidence that what the system decides aligns with the organization's intentions.

At ACME, the disconnect between intent and implementation became clear only after the policy engine was in full production. Policies had multiplied across teams, each tailored for a specific service or use case. Though they made sense individually, together they showed no overarching strategy. The